The Voting Rights Act of 1965

89th Congress · August 6, 1965

Source: Voting Rights Act of 1965. Public domain. The core provisions.

> Enforcing the Fifteenth Amendment, the act banned the literacy tests and devices used to disenfranchise Black voters and required "preclearance" of voting changes in covered states — the most effective civil rights law in U.S. history.

SEC. 2. No voting qualification or prerequisite to voting, or standard, practice, or procedure shall be imposed or applied by any State or political subdivision to deny or abridge the right of any citizen of the United States to vote on account of race or color.

[. . .]

SEC. 5. Whenever a State or political subdivision with respect to which the prohibitions set forth in section 4(a) are in effect shall enact or seek to administer any voting qualification . . . different from that in force or effect on November 1, 1964, such State or subdivision may institute an action in the United States District Court for the District of Columbia for a declaratory judgment that such qualification . . . does not have the purpose and will not have the effect of denying or abridging the right to vote on account of race or color.